

Mango sticky rice: A Thai recipe for sweet learning & shared understanding

A symbolic dessert for leading multicultural teams



Chef's prelude

Mango sticky rice teaches that harmony is not uniformity. It is the craft of holding different textures together: the firmness of sticky rice, the vibrancy of mango, and the soothing sweetness of coconut milk. Leading multicultural teams requires a similar sensibility. Effective leaders blend cultural humility, cognitive plurality, and reflective gratitude to create shared meaning, psychological safety, and continuous learning. Symbolically, this dessert guides leaders in weaving diverse perspectives into cohesive, high-performing teams (Fischer & Sitkin, 2023; Graamans, 2025)

Step 1: Sticky rice - cultural humility for shared meaning

Hook et al. (2013) conceptualize cultural humility as a sustained commitment to self-evaluation, openness to cultural difference, and awareness of power imbalances. Leaders “prepare the rice” by slowing down their assumptions and inviting others to shape interpretation. This aligns with the sensemaking theory. Through short sensemaking rituals, like shared reflections or clarifying questions, teams build a collective understanding of experiences (Weick, 1995).

Like rice that must soak to soften, shared meaning requires time, patience, and genuine curiosity. Without this foundation, teams risk fragmentation. With it, they cohere and navigate ambiguity more effectively.

Micro-practice: Begin projects with members naming their cultural expectations of teamwork.

Step 2: Mango slices - diverse knowledge systems & cognitive plurality

Mango brings color, symbolizing epistemic richness. Leaders “serve the mango” by designing interactions where different logics can surface: rotating facilitation so influence shifts across cultural lines, encouraging multiple interpretations of challenges and valuing local knowledge alongside global expertise.

This reflects research on cognitive diversity and cultural intelligence, which enhance creativity and decision quality (Earley & Ang, 2003). It also echoes paradoxical leadership, where integrating divergent viewpoints strengthens adaptability (Waldman & Bowen, 2016). Mango’s sweetness emerges when insights are fully expressed, highlighting the value of underrepresented perspectives.

Micro-practice: During problem-solving sessions, assign one member to play “cultural perspective challenger”, offering how the issue might be interpreted from another cultural frame.

Ingredients

1 cup of sticky rice

for cultural humility and shared meaning

8 slices of mango

for diverse knowledge systems and cognitive plurality

500ml coconut milk

for gratitude and reflective learning cycles

Taste profile

Of effective multicultural leadership



Sweetness

Empathy and gratitude



Tanginess

Healthy tension between perspectives



Aroma

Curiosity and active listening



Texture

Smooth collaboratino with crunchy diversity



Aftertaste

Shared understanding and team cohesion



Prep time
10 min



Cook time
60 min

Step 3: Coconut milk - gratitude & reflective learning cycles

Coconut milk softens and lifts the flavours, symbolizing how gratitude and reflection elevate multicultural learning. Leaders “pour the coconut milk” by embedding rituals that normalize appreciation and curiosity:

- brief gratitude check-outs,
- cross-cultural learning circles,
- short after-action reflections after key milestones.

These practices build psychological safety (Edmondson, 1999), enabling the deeper layer of double-loop learning (Argyris & Schön, 1978) where assumptions, not just actions, can be questioned.

Steady, intentional reflection enriches the entire team climate, helping multicultural teams learn with cultural difference rather than despite it.

Micro-practice: End each week with “3 Sweet Drops”: one appreciation, one insight, one changed assumption.

Step 4: Blending the dish: leadership as symbolic craft

When sticky rice, mango, and coconut milk come together, the dessert becomes more than ingredients, it becomes a shared experience.

In the same way, inclusive leadership blends:

- cultural humility (rice),
- diverse cognition (mango), and
- reflective gratitude (coconut milk)

into a coherent cultural experience for the team (Carmeli et al, 2010).

This is the essence of symbolic leadership (Hatch & Cunliffe, 2013):

Using metaphors, rituals, and shared symbols to create meaning, identity, and direction.

By learning from a Thai dessert, and respecting the cultural wisdom it represents, leaders discover that sweet learning comes from integration, not assimilation.



Additional tips

The sweet spoon ritual

Once a week, team members share:

- One thing they learned (mango)
- One thing they appreciated (coconut milk)
- One perspective they hadn’t considered before (sticky rice)

A simple ritual that keeps multicultural learning active, one spoonful at a time.



Serving tip

Best enjoyed in small, frequent portions. Serve during team check-ins or project milestones to keep curiosity warm, perspectives fresh, and gratitude sweet.

Chef’s warning



Avoid burning the rice

Don’t jump to conclusions about someone’s intention or communication style



Don’t over-sweeten

Don’t try to make everything agreeable. Healthy disagreement is part of the recipe



Don’t serve cold

Feedback must be timely and culturally aware